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The Tilt

Polling Averages Can Be Useful, but What’s Underneath Has Changed

This year, a wave of polls from Republican-leaning firms is driving the averages.



By Nate Cohn

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You’re reading The Tilt newsletter, for Times subscribers only. Nate Cohn, The Times’s chief political analyst, makes sense of the latest political data.

The polls show Republicans gaining heading into the final stretch. They’ve pulled ahead on the generic ballot in the race for the House, and they’ve fought into a closely contested race for Senate control.

You can see that for yourself on our table of polling averages. To give you a sense of the uncertainty, we’ve also added what might happen if the polls err in the exact same way they did in 2018 or 2020.

2022 Senate Polling Averages

	POLLING LEADER	WITH 2020-LIKE POLL ERROR	WITH 2018-LIKE POLL ERROR
United States*	+2 Republican	+6 Republican	+3 Republican
Ohio	+5 Republican	+11 Republican	+8 Republican
North Carolina	+4 Republican	+5 Republican	Even
Wisconsin	+4 Republican	+11 Republican	+2 Republican

Nevada	+1 Republican	+3 Republican	+2 Democrat
Georgia	Even	+2 Republican	Even
Pennsylvania	Even	+3 Republican	+1 Republican
Arizona	+2 Democrat	+1 Republican	+3 Democrat
New Hampshire	+3 Democrat	Even	Even
Colorado	+11 Democrat	+9 Democrat	+14 Democrat

*Figures for the U.S. represent polling estimates of the generic ballot, which asks voters whether they'll vote for the Democrat or Republican for Congress. • The New York Times

On average, Republicans lead by two points on the generic ballot — which asks voters whether they'll vote for the Democrat or Republican for Congress — and have pulled into very tight Senate races in Pennsylvania, Georgia and Nevada, where Democrats were once thought to have the advantage.

This simple poll average is like many others you might have seen over the years. It weights the most recent polls more heavily. It gives more weight to pollsters that belong to a professional polling organization (they tend to be far less biased over the longer term). It doesn't contain some of the fancier bells and whistles, like an adjustment for whether a poll tends to lean toward Republicans or Democrats.

But in one important respect, this average is very different from polling averages you've seen in prior years: The pollsters making up the average are very different.

Many stalwarts of political polling over the last decade — Monmouth University, Quinnipiac University, ABC/Washington Post, CNN/SSRS, Fox News, New York Times/Siena College, Marist College — have conducted far fewer surveys, especially in the battleground states, than they have in recent years. In some cases, these pollsters have conducted no recent polls at all.

And on the flip side, there has been a wave of polls by firms like the Trafalgar Group, Rasmussen Reports, Insider Advantage and others that have tended to produce much more Republican-friendly results than the traditional pollsters. None adhere to industry standards for transparency or data collection. In some states, nearly all of the recent polls were conducted by Republican-leaning firms.

This creates a big challenge for a simple polling average like this one. From state to state, Democrats or Republicans might seem to be doing much better or much worse, simply depending on which kind of pollster has conducted a survey most recently. The race may seem to swing back and forth, from week to week.

Pennsylvania is a fine example. Last week, four Republican-leaning firms — Patriot Polling, co/efficient, Wick and Insider Advantage — showed Dr. Mehmet Oz with a lead. This week, four conventional pollsters have shown John Fetterman tied or ahead — Suffolk University/USA Today, New York Times/Siena College, Fox News and Muhlenberg College.

Put it all together, and our average in Pennsylvania is just about tied. Maybe that’s what the final result will be. Or maybe the result will more squarely conform with one group’s estimates.

For now, this much is clear: Which pollsters have surveyed a state most recently is a big factor in determining whether the numbers look better for Republicans or Democrats. And this year, the polls that are driving the average are quite different.

Nate Cohn is The Times’s chief political analyst. He covers elections, polling and demographics for The Upshot. Before joining The Times in 2013, he was a staff writer for The New Republic. More about Nate Cohn

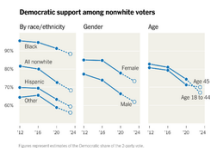
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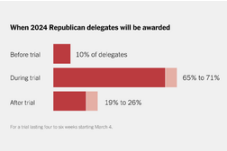
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